

SUMMARY KEYWORDS

couples, relationships, gottman, scale, conceptualize, formal assessment, shanghai, italy, therapists, people, therapy, bit, find, big, training, interesting, decision, important, emotions, practice

SPEAKERS

Interviewer; Therapist

Interviewer 00:00

There you go, record. There you go. All right. I just want to get the start, I just want to get a better sense of your practice. Is it right that you're basing your practice in [Country] and you provide your services within?

Therapist 00:16

Yeah. So it's kind of a tricky thing now that we're in such a globalized reality, but I'm qualified to practice in [Country]. But now that there's a lot of online and zoom sessions, I have clients who are based kind of all over the world, most of them find me because I have the talent base. So maybe they're expats in [Country], and then maybe their work takes them abroad. But we continue online. And I've had a few who just kind of randomly find me on the internet. And so we have sessions. Yeah. But then the in person practice, of course, is in [City].

Interviewer 00:55

And yes, is it also correct that your primary modality is in systematic family therapy?

Therapist 01:03

Now, so this is I was reading the material that you sent me and I do find this a really interesting topic. So my, my training in, let's say, the formal training, what got me to qualify in [Country], as a therapist, and to be able to practice couples therapy is much more generic. My training is in transcultural psychotherapy, which is like the I can see that that look because it's very niche. So it's psychodynamic psychotherapy, with a lot of anthropology into it. The idea being that the training allows us to work with people from many different cultural backgrounds. Because a lot of the times maybe you study like a western approach, and that's great. But then you might have other cultural practices, especially when we're talking about families and couples. And so the training gives us kind of a wider view to be able to work with that. I say it's generic, because technically speaking in [Country], I can work with children, adults, couples, they say, go out there and do what you got to do. So then I got my own bits and pieces of training. So I did some training in systemic family therapy. This was when I was living in [Country 2], around [Year]. And then I did some more training in the Gottman couples therapy method. Yeah. And those are the only certified things and then bits and pieces along the way. But I thought it was interesting that the materials you sent me because I definitely feel that there's a few like this is their approach. Kind of like a uniform approach of dealing with couples.. Does that make sense?

Interviewer 02:58

Yes, I believe that what you were talking about the transcultural psychotherapy definitely wouldn't be one of the major schools so I was adjusting to.

Therapist 03:14

being a multi or bicultural person myself, and you know, my family was multicultural. Like I want to know how this works.

Interviewer 03:27

Are there specific types of couples that you provide your services to? Or that you specialize in?

Therapist 03:33

Yeah, so the niche for me is, well, first of all, being able to provide therapy in [Language 1] in [Language 2], so a lot of [Language-speaking] people. And then what that looks like in terms of couples is most of the couples I work with are bicultural. And just a lot of them would be like a foreigner, and an [Nationality]. And then sometimes I also have couples that are from two different cultures. But who like [Country] is their third culture. There's always this cultural aspect.

Interviewer 04:08

Allright. Of course, that there are a whole broad range of issues. But when your clients come to you what is usually the presenting issue or their event that they seek your service?

Therapist 04:19

I would say that's a good question. I think that's a little bit culture based. I think that most couples come because they're just tired of fighting. And those are the harder ones to work with. Because it's like we've, we've come to the end of the line. This is our last resort. But I'm also finding that there's couples, usually younger couples, and usually, I would say more [Nationality] or people who've lived in the [Country 3] where I find that there's more of an awareness of we shouldn't wait till things get really bad. Let's go in and get the tools to keep our religion kinship healthy. So sometimes I also have it but this is a minority. And I noticed that it's younger couples coming from the states have this idea that a therapist is not someone you go to when you're really sick. But someone that can give you the tools to really build like a solid foundation to kind of like, oh, maybe we're thinking of getting married, setting up a family, we'd like to have a conversation with the expert and relationships to make sure that we're going in the right direction.

Interviewer 05:29

That's super interesting.

Therapist 05:31

The third one. I think for a lot of couples that I see, their trauma is part of it, although they wouldn't necessarily present as Oh, we've had trauma, they might present and things are falling apart, or my partner seems really depressed. And I don't know what to do about that. And so when we go into it, we

find that maybe there's been like a miscarriage or COVID, you know, thrown up a lot of issues, or maybe there's been a death in the family. So that's like the third main category.

Interviewer 06:09

It's amazing to hear. And do you do any formal assessment when they come in?

Therapist 06:14

No.. I don't. I tried for a while the Gottman assessment tools. But it just didn't really fit me. It was like interesting what came up. But then it was a little bit simplistic. And so no, I don't. And I also I haven't formally been trained to assess formal assessments, I just kind of let that go.

Interviewer 06:38

And aside from the Gottman assessment tools that you've used before, are there other scales that you use in your practice?

Therapist 06:45

Not for couples, and generally not? I've tried different things, and then just realize it doesn't suit me.

Interviewer 06:53

Why is that ?

Therapist 06:54

Good question. Well, first of all, I would have to blame my training. And again, because it's working with such a wide variety of people, there's just like some, some categories of either people and backgrounds or presenting problems where like a questionnaire just doesn't really give a lot of useful feedback, I find sometimes I find that the feedback of a questionnaire and the scoring almost helps more the client and like, oh, I have anxiety. Okay, so, so the score told you that, I haven't found that it really helps. I have to say that this is probably an important piece. When I do think that there's complex things going on. I always refer to psychiatrist for a formal assessment, because I find that they're much better qualified and can really use the right tools. They're knowledgeable about how to interpret them, and then they feed that information to me. So it's not like I don't do it all together, I just don't feel like I'm the best suited professional.

Interviewer 08:09

So of course, you don't do like formal assessment, but you're just also of course, informally, you know, assess with what's the purpose, etcetera. How long does it usually take until, you know, like, you get a better sense of, I know, like, a broad range. But yeah,

Therapist 08:26

I think that it's, it's kind of like an ongoing I my mind, I kind of reason in modules. This is where maybe like summer breaks, and winter breaks help, because it's like, okay, so what are our goals for this piece, and sometimes, they might give you like, huge goals. So this assessment is also to help them fine tune, you know, my idea of what the issue is, and then transform that into a working goal. But then, you know, you might start working on something at one level, and then you realize, oh, there's

something actually much deeper going on. And then when we're working with couples, sometimes, you know, as things come up, there might be that thing of what you consider individual counseling, or would you consider speaking someone to work on these issues that are actually not that they impact the couple, but you might want to work on them individually. So I see it as like an ongoing, you know, you have an initial assessment, you do some work, and then you start to go a little bit deeper and address that to kind of keep coming back to—

Interviewer 09:36

when you were using the Gottman assessment. Did you have any challenges when you were using the scale?

Therapist 09:44

No, so they have this automated system? Right, so you send a couple, are you familiar with it?

Interviewer 09:51

No, no, actually,

Therapist 09:52

okay. Okay. I think they've done an amazing job. So basically, you send a couple a link to and they go on to their platform. It's all HIPAA compliance, GDPR compliant. And the Capitol fills out a lot of questions like 100 questions, it takes about an hour that they can do in different parts. And then the system automatically scores it, and sends me all the information, including just some tips of the types of interventions. So it's woven into their method. So as a couple scored high in conflict, actually go much more in detail. Here's some interventions that you might want to consider, because we see that I don't know [Name] tends to hold his emotions in and [Name] tends to show her emotions a lot more. So here are the tools that you might want to use.

Interviewer 10:51

All right now, that's very, I might have gotten it from a different term, but yes, quite familiar with a friendship and a domestic scale. All right, perfect. Okay. And if it's alright, that you can ask how much the this core skills cost you back then,

Therapist 11:10

um, I still have like access to the platform. So I still, you know, once in a while, there's a couple that I'm like, okay, that that could be useful. But I don't remember. It's, I'm gonna say like maybe 25 euros or dollars per couple. I think somewhere around there, I might be wrong and might be off by a little bit. If you go on the website, you'll see

Interviewer 11:39

perfect. Across the year is different therapists, as they have indicated in the email as well, different therapists and different researchers have characterized them construct of relationship quality. Let's differentiate from each other. Guys, I wanted to get your own view about it. For you what is the relationship quality?

Therapist 11:59

Okay, so one thing I'll circle back to your question, one thing I didn't say before is, when you were asking about the training, what I've been doing is a lot of reading, that qualifies as training on Emotionally Focused Therapy. And also, [Name]. And I don't remember what his approach is called. Are you familiar with him? Okay. And what I appreciate about the approaches, is thinking that, okay, constructing this as I speak, I think we get into relationships to feel safe. That's like the first level, and then to be able to kind of like, expand ourselves, reach her dreams, be able to express yourself. So that's like the second level. And I find that a lot of the times when couples are having issues, it's because they either don't feel safe, or they don't feel that they can kind of become their true selves within that relationship. I don't know if this answers your questions. But I think that this is what we're looking for when we want to be in a long term, monogamous relationship is in this relationship, I feel safe, and I feel that I can turn into the human being that I want to be.

Interviewer 13:26

That's super interesting. And I think you've already kind of drew the shape and this but I might just ask as well for you what differentiates couples that high relationship quality, and those who have low relationship quality?

Therapist 13:42

Well, this is where I really liked the Gottman method. Because I think that, you know, in all the research that they've done, they've kind of given me the answer. So you know, the things that do work, the predictors of divorce and the predictors of successful relationships. So I think there's people being able to tune into one's own emotions and to be able to verbalize that for the partner. Super important and of course, to be able to listen to your their part to your partner, verbalize their emotions, tune into what's going on with yourself and understand and also the ability to soothe like self soothe, if things are escalating. So I think that emotional call emotional intelligence, and communication is a big part of it. And I think also, I know this is a big one in the Gottman method, but making each other's life dreams come true. I think that's a big one because I think that's where a lot of couples start to split apart when they feel like I feel like I want to have this dream. I see this a lot and more like cultural couples, because like really, tangibly I want to live in [Country]? No, I want to live in [Country]. And it's like, wow, how do you work with that? How do you make that work?

Interviewer 15:08

Yeah, interesting. So would you say that these things that you were talking about, like emotional intelligence and communication, you know, listening to your own emotion, being able to verbalize that your partner, etc? Are these the most important things in the high quality relationship? Or what would you say are the most important things in the high quality?

Therapist 15:31

That's funny, because I'm thinking, sometimes when you do a lot of therapy, it gets so caught up in to what doesn't work. So the lack of that emotional intelligence, I think, was definitely geared towards relationships that fall apart. So high quality relationships, I think just that open communication is really important, because along with that goes, that emotional intimacy, and that emotional intimacy can also lead to feeling safe. And then it can also lead to sexual intimacy and sexual satisfaction, because that's

another big part of it. So I think it's that ability to feel safe enough to enter that very intimate space in which one feels really, really safe, and that they can really be themselves.

Interviewer 16:26

Interesting. And does how you conceptualize relationships often differ from how your clients conceptualize relationships? In what way? And does it matter for therapy? How does it matter for

Therapist 16:41

it's interesting, I always share with my clients that we don't get taught to do relationships, and we get given very little vocabulary to talk about relationships. So even this question, you know, if I were to ask a couple on the first session, how do you conceptualize relationships? I think they would just look at me completely blank. Because, you know, that's the question that people don't really talk about. But I do think that there's sometimes also this kind of, like pop culture idea of, is he or she the right one. And I think that's just a bit of a dangerous way of conceptualizing relationships of you just, it's kind of like a trial and error a hit and miss, until you hit the jackpot, and it's the right person. And so sometimes, couples might have an idea that relationships need to be worked on and nurtured. They don't know what that looks like, hence them coming into therapy.

Interviewer 17:43

All right. Is that usually the case as well, for your clients that they have this pop culture idea? Is that the usual conceptualization of relationships?

Therapist 17:55

No, I think it also depends on the age, you know, and where they're at. I mean, if they've been married for [21-25] years and raised [1-5] kids, they're gonna have, they're not going to have that pop culture idea. If they're younger than they might be a little bit more like, Oh, before I settle with this person, I want to know if they're the right one. So that might play into it more. So yeah, the I think the way a couple conceptualizes relationships does depend a lot on how much experience they've had and relationships themselves. Sometimes the cultural aspects play into it a little bit. Sometimes there's like big gender differences. I think if we're talking about if I think of like two different polls. Gender roles are a big thing. And sometimes they're just conceptualized differently, even within the couple, you know, what's the role of a man fall of a father who's a husband and a father. And for example, in Italy, and particularly in southern Italy, that might look more traditional, the father is the breadwinner, and make certain types of decisions in the house about finances. This is kind of it's starting to fade out but there is, you know, Harriet traditional heritage. And maybe a young woman from the west coast in the United States might have like a completely different view of the gender roles. So that that think influences a lot. The gender roles and the construct of whatever relationship is how do two people make a relationship work and make it you know, life together work if the gender roles are really different, that can work if they're both on board, but if they're not on board, and they need things to be equal, and they're not then What does one do with that? All right kind of went off?

Interviewer 20:04

No, no, that's very interesting to hear. And we also know that that relationship is a complex system. It involves Love, Sex identity, relationship maintenance, conflict satisfaction, all that. During therapy, how do you decide which one to focus on, or which one of the complex system to target?

Therapist 20:27

I think especially when I have high conflict couples, we first do a lot of work before we address any issue. A lot of work on emotions, self soothing, understanding the dynamics, this is where the Emotionally Focused approach comes in understanding that when you have this tone, that other person has this kind of reaction. Because if we don't do that groundwork first, then we can talk about finances, parenting, where to live, you know, making big decisions about careers. But if we haven't addressed the dynamic and talking about it, and the emotions that come up, and any of those conversations are going to totally fall apart.

Interviewer 21:16

Interesting. It really starts with almost like a skills building. A tool giving before before and how do you determine when to end the couples therapy?

Therapist 21:29

Okay. I think that almost always comes up with the couples. And usually what we do is, depending on the couple, but I think one thing that works is to say for a while, let's just meet once a month. Okay. And then And then sometimes in doing that, then there's like a summer break. That's like, Okay, well, we end here, so it's [Month]. How about this? How about you reach out to me, moving forward, if at any point you want to brush up on anything we've done or if anything comes up? So there's like a maintenance period. And then I leave it to them to, to contact me.

Interviewer 22:14

Usually, of course, again, a broad range of usually how long does that does that take until like, successful? Until that is only like

Therapist 22:24

from the first day they walk in the end? It depends. It's also interesting to know, I have kind of have this internal statistic that if couples come for more than four sessions, I think some drop out within the first sessions of those couples that are like, Oh, well, I thought she was going to be the referee to tell us that I'm right., when once they see that that's gonna happen. Sometimes they drop out, or for whatever other reasons. And then I think maybe like, a year, a year and a half, would be a good time. And within that, it could be weekly, it could be maybe sometimes bi weekly, if they're wanting to work, take some momentum, and then it could be stretching it out to

Interviewer 23:17

once a month, quite intensive, weekly for a year and a half.

Therapist 23:21

Yeah, I've never had that. But I've had maybe some ups and downs. Maybe there's some issues. Sometimes there's like time bound issues that they need to make decisions on. And that's fine. What

you might do. Okay, let's meet twice next week. So we can really explore this issue before you decide on I don't know, the mortgage or whatever, or your mom's coming to town and you want to both be prepared for that.

Interviewer 23:49

And are there was the usual treatment goals what you were talking about earlier, just like and the fight there and resolve the cultural differences? Are those usually the treatment goals that you guys set out for?

Therapist 24:05

Yeah, thank you for the high conflict couples. Yeah. And then of course, it's never phrases to end the fighting, but to learn the best tools to address when fighting comes up. And then, I think sometimes there's If couples are coming at a crossroads of whatever's going on in their lives, that could look like I need to make an important decision about my career about where to live or whether to have kids or not, then that might be you know, to resolve this crossroads and, and share with each other and make a joint decision or in any case. Yeah, does that make sense?

Interviewer 24:49

Yes. Because it's super interesting for me, for example, if one wants to live in [Country], and another wants to live in in you know, [Country], how then is a process of making them Yeah, that's that's a very difficult decision.

Therapist 25:02

Yes. So it makes it a lot easier if it's not a time bound decision. Because then if there's like a deadline, it's like if the decision has to be made, but if we have the luxury of not having a deadline and not having to rush through it, then I think it's really valuable to unpack. So what does living in [Country] mean to you? Well, it's work prospects, or it's an adventure, or I want to be closer to my family who lives in Thailand, whatever, I'm making this up. Well, okay, so what would London mean to you to that partner, so and vice versa. So we can really unpack what their beliefs are about making a decision to understand well, is there any part of it, so for example, you all decide to live in [Country]. But for the husband who's Italian, like, it's going to be really hard to be away from the family. So to start putting this into context, if you move to [Country], it's going to be really important for the two of you to understand how he can be in touch with the family by going to look like traveling, making holiday vacations or getting the family over or meeting halfway. So to kind of start setting the what's important for both of you.

Interviewer 26:26

And making sure that they are all satisfied at the end Yeah. All right. So actually, we're near the end of the interview with with, with what I was seeing in the email, I'm not sure if it was very explicit. But what we are currently hoping to do with a research project is actually to develop a relationship quality scale, that better represents the relationship really, as a complex system that would also help therapists and treatment planning and evaluation. How interested would you be in this kind of scale?

Therapist 27:02

Oh, i think it would be great.

Interviewer 27:04

Interesting. All right. And what would you be looking for, like, personally or professionally in a newly developed scale, such as

Therapist 27:16

trying to think like in terms of the Gottman set, because that's like something that that I have access to? And what would be more? I don't know, I think, something I need, and it's already out there. But it would be like having a community of other colleagues who are also using the scale. I think that would feel really important to me. And I know that there's like a whole Gottman community. But I've just, you know, it's not a big thing here in [Country], almost nobody knows of it. So it's not. Whereas I think if I were practicing in the [Country], that might be more of a thing. I'm

Interviewer 28:00

sorry. Why is it important for you is to have that community using scale?

Therapist 28:07

Well, I think just to be able to discuss, discuss the results of the scale and the outcomes. think sometimes you might see the outcome of like a questionnaire filled out and you know, somebody scores three out of 10 on something, but you've spoken to that person, it's like, well, this doesn't match up, or what does this mean? Or what do I do with this information? So I'm trying to give you more useful.

Interviewer 28:47

Okay, it's okay. All right, because I was thinking as well of course, we want this scale to be useful, like above everything else, it will be like cross culturally generalizable and valid, but above all, it should be useful for therapists. What would a useful scale look like for you aside from having a community of practitioners using it?

Therapist 29:16

Okay, I think I know one, one. Okay. Here's the thing that I don't really like about the Gottman scale. As much as I understand their reasoning. Most of their questions for the couples are yes and no.

Interviewer 29:31

Oh, okay.

Therapist 29:32

Okay, I kind of get that but but it's no, I and then okay, I have another thing this this might be a little bit more useful. There should also be a questionnaire that the therapist fills out after they've done the assessment. And then if those numbers could be like, shaken up by the algorithm, to give the outputs because currently from the Gottman I have the couple answer a bunch of yes or no question. It's already it's like it's not we really miss the nuances. And then I read that and then I, myself integrate it with my own assessment. But it would be really helpful if there was a scale. Because I'm imagining that

you're thinking about something to fill out that then like an algorithm gives you an output, right? If within that, then I have my own set of questions to answer that would then plug all the information together and give an output.

Note: The interview is missing 7 minutes.